

LIVEKIT · STAFF DEVELOPER ADVOCATE, COMMUNITY AND EVENTS

The face of LiveKit in the Bay Area, with a hackathon kit already built

Matthew Karsten · real-time media engineer turned developer advocate · September 2026

50,000+ concurrent-user streaming platform · 10,000+ developers grown at ZetaChain · speaker at EthCC 2025, ETH NYC, ETH Denver · 4x hackathon winner · 24-tool LiveKit MCP server, tested against a live server

Events and community first, with a hands-on technical bar

"You'll be the face of LiveKit in the Bay Area and beyond, driving awareness with developers who may not yet know us."

"Plan, host, and participate in events including meetups, hackathons, developer workshops, and conferences."

"Serve as a feedback loop for the company, bringing back developer perspectives, industry trends, and emerging patterns."

"Hands-on technical background (comfortable writing code samples, running demos, or building prototypes)."

WHAT I BUILT FOR THIS APPLICATION

livekit-ops-mcp: 24 tools that let an agent operate a LiveKit deployment

GROUP	TOOLS
Rooms	server_health, room_create, room_list, room_delete, room_update_metadata
Participants	participant_list, participant_get, participant_remove, participant_mute_track, participant_update
Tokens and data	token_create, token_verify, data_send
Egress and ingress	egress_start_room_composite, egress_list, egress_stop, ingress_create, ingress_list, ingress_delete
Workshop kit	workshop_spinup, workshop_join_sheet, workshop_status, workshop_broadcast, workshop_teardown

```
$ npm run smoke    (livekit-server 1.13.7 --dev, Sept 14, 2026)
[02] server_health → ok=true latencyMs=48.5
[03] workshop_spinup → 2 rooms: smoke-...-otters
      (sid RM_2CTLxz9gvyRy, 2 seats + mentor); ...-herons
[04] token_verify → valid=true sub=otters-seat-1
[06] rtc-node Room.connect(ws://localhost:7880)
      as otters-seat-1 → isConnected=true, sid
PA_5Z8GYhBztT3s
[07] participant_list → 1: otters-seat-1 [ACTIVE]
[09] data_send → 23 bytes; participant received
      "hello from the operator"
[11] workshop_status → rooms=2 participants=1
[12] participant_remove → client saw Disconnected
[16] workshop_teardown → deleted 2
[17] room_list → 0 rooms

SMOKE PASS: 17 steps, 0 failures
```

Run a 25-team hackathon in five prompts

- 1 "Check the LiveKit server is up." `server_health`
- 2 "Spin up the SF Voice Agent Hackathon: 25 teams, 4 seats each, tokens good for 10 hours."
`workshop_spinup` creates 25 rooms, 100 seat tokens, 25 mentor tokens.
- 3 "Make me a printable join sheet."
`workshop_join_sheet` : one page per team, a QR code per seat.
- 4 "How are the teams doing? Tell everyone 30 minutes left." `workshop_status` shows the quiet rooms; `workshop_broadcast` runs the clock.
- 5 "Tear it all down." `workshop_teardown` , then `room_list` shows zero.

Why this matters for the role

- The host spends the day with builders, not with a terminal.
- Mentor tokens carry admin and record rights; seat tokens do not.
- Status data is the feedback loop: which teams went quiet, and when.
- The kit ships as the reference template for community-run LiveKit hackathons anywhere.

Five Bay Area events, two conference submissions

October: listen, then host

- Weeks 1 to 2: attend three existing SF meetups, ten developer interviews, channel audit
- Oct 11: CFP to AI Engineer Code Summit (SF, Nov 10 to 12)
- Oct 21: Meetup #1, "Voice agents in production", 60 to 80 devs
- Oct 28: Workshop, "Your first voice agent in 60 minutes", 30 seats
- Nov 1: CFP to SCaLE 24x (Pasadena, Apr 1 to 4, 2027)

November: the hackathon

- Nov 11: Meetup #2, telephony and SIP, as a Summit-week side event
- Nov 21: Bay Area Voice Agent Hackathon, Saturday, 100 builders, 25 teams, run on the kit
- Judging over a real call, not slides; prizes in LiveKit Cloud credits

December: showcase and report

- Dec 9: Meetup #3, hackathon winners plus roadmap AMA with a product lead
- Weeks 10 to 12: winners' tutorials, day-90 community report, Q1 2027 calendar

Every event produces three artifacts within 72 hours

Recap

Blog post within 72 hours: what was shown, what people asked, photos, links to every repo. Social thread the same day, scheduled with Marketing.

Demo

A 2 to 4 minute captioned video per talk, cut for X, LinkedIn and YouTube. I build video pipelines for a living; producing it is not the bottleneck.

Tutorial

One per workshop or hackathon track, starting from a repo with tests, ending in something the reader runs on LiveKit Cloud.

From the hackathon: a winners' showcase, three tutorials rebuilt from the winning projects as open-source starter repos, and a "what 25 teams built in 12 hours" write-up of patterns and friction. Nothing is presented that has not already been written down as a runnable repo, so the three artifacts are cuts of one source.

How community signal reaches Product: counted, quoted, on a schedule

Intake

- Two-question card at every event: what did you try to build, where did you get stuck
- `workshop_status` and `participant_list` during workshops: which rooms went quiet, which teams never published media
- Channel triage twice a week (Slack, GitHub issues, forum), tagged by product area and failure mode
- Ten developer interviews in month 1, five a month after

Output

- Weekly field notes to Product, DevRel and PMM: top five friction points with quotes and counts
- GitHub issues with reproduction steps for anything hit twice
- Monthly 30-minute signal review with Product and Engineering
- Day-90 community report and the Q1 plan

Anecdotes from a hallway do not survive a roadmap meeting. Counted, reproducible signal does.

METRICS I WOULD REPORT AT DAY 90

Numbers, not adjectives

METRIC	HOW IT IS COUNTED	TARGET
Meetup attendance	Checked-in attendees per meetup, month over month	60 / 75 / 90
Workshop completions	Seats that reached a working voice agent in the hour	24 of 30
Hackathon builders and teams	Checked in; teams that joined their room (workshop_status)	100 / 25
Repos created at the hackathon	Public repos submitted at judging that call LiveKit	25
Teams with a working demo	Demo ran over a real call at judging	18 of 25
Activation	Attendees creating a LiveKit Cloud project within 14 days (UTM-matched)	30%
Feedback delivered	Weekly field notes / GitHub issues with repro / monthly reviews	12 / 10+ / 3
New community members	Net new in LiveKit's community channel, attributed to events	300

WHY ME

Real-time media is my home turf, and I have run the room

50,000+

concurrent users on a streaming backend I architected for DirecTV LATAM, AT&T and IBM (HLS, FFmpeg, GStreamer). Plus Kino, a 7-crate Rust HLS/DASH player, and a GPU/NVENC pipeline at 16x encode, VMAF 95.8.

10,000+

active developers grown as Developer Relations Engineer at ZetaChain: docs, SDKs, starter kits, and the Discord and Telegram channels. 15+ production MCP servers, one at 1,000+ users, a 73-tool Hedera server.

3 stages, 4 wins

Speaker at EthCC 2025, ETH NYC and ETH Denver. Four hackathon wins as a competitor, so I know what a kit feels like at 2 a.m. Three published technical books. 139 public repositories.

Location: Niles, Michigan today, relocating to the San Francisco Bay Area for this role. Travel for conferences and events: yes.

LINKS

Everything here is public and runnable

- The project: github.com/ExpertVagabond/livekit-ops-mcp (MIT, 24 tools, unit tests, live-server smoke)
- The 90-day plan: [LiveKit_DevAdvocate_90Day_Proposal.pdf](#), attached with this deck
- Everything else: github.com/ExpertVagabond · karsten.cv · x.com/expertvagabond
- Contact: matthewkarstenconnects@gmail.com · (269) 262-2808 · linkedin.com/in/matthew-karsten

First thing I would do in week 1: run the workshop kit against LiveKit Cloud with your team in the room, and book Meetup #1.